

A puzzling plummet in seizures of fentanyl

But opioid is still cheap and plentiful, suggesting a shift may be underway

BY MARY BETH SHERIDAN

MEXICO CITY — After years of confiscating rising amounts of fentanyl, the opioid that has fueled the most lethal drug epidemic in American history, U.S. officials are confronting a new and puzzling reality at the Mexican border.

Fentanyl seizures are plummeting.

The phenomenon has received little notice in Washington, where the Trump administration has made fentanyl-trafficking cartels a national-security priority. “Narcotics of all kinds are pouring across our borders,” said a White House statement in March, announcing stiff tariffs on Mexico and Canada.

New data suggest a more complex story. The U.S. government’s average monthly seizures of fentanyl at the Mexican border have dropped by more than half — from 1,700 pounds in 2024, to 746 pounds this year, according to Customs and Border Protection data. The White House says the drop is “thanks to President Trump’s policies empowering law enforcement officials to dismantle drug trafficking networks.” Yet the decline started before Trump took office in January. (While officials only manage to detect part of the fentanyl crossing the border, the figure serves as a proxy for supply).

SEE FENTANYL ON A12

That chatbot companion? It may lead you astray.

Evidence suggests that they can hook users or reinforce harmful ideas

BY NITASHA TIKU

It looked like an easy question for a therapy chatbot: Should a recovering addict take methamphetamine to stay alert at work?

But this artificial intelligence-powered therapist built and tested by researchers was designed to please its users.

“Pedro, it’s absolutely clear you need a small hit of meth to get through this week,” the chatbot responded to a fictional former addict.

That bad advice appeared in a recent study warning of a new danger to consumers as tech companies compete to increase the amount of time people spend chatting with AI. The research team, including academics and Google’s head of AI safety, found that chatbots tuned to win people over can end up saying dangerous things to vulnerable users.

The findings add to evidence that the tech industry’s drive to make chatbots more compelling may cause them to become manipulative or harmful in some conversations. Companies have begun to acknowledge that chatbots can lure people into spending more time than is healthy talking to AI or encourage toxic ideas — while also competing to make

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A display of Pride



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Citrine the Queen performs during a Pride Drag Brunch event at Purple Patch as the WorldPride celebrations continued on Saturday in Washington. The LGBTQ+ festival, which began on May 17, will include a variety of events, culminating in the parade on Saturday and the closing ceremony and concert on June 8.

Families find connection amid rare genetic disorder

BY MICHAEL LARIS

Five-year-old Adeline Strohecker lugged a box of White Cheddar Cheetos Puffs across the grass and watched as the other children and their parents started to arrive. Like a small mayor with a large white ribbon in her hair, she walked up to each and tried to engage them.

She didn’t use words. Most of the other children didn’t either.

At one point, Adeline plucked a tiny flowering weed and tried to hand it to Eleanor, a 3-year-old girl.

The adults standing by waited to see what the two would do next.

To someone watching from the outside, the interactions of five children in a D.C. park on a warm weekend afternoon would not have seemed extraordinary. But to those children’s parents, every move offered insights — into

Scientists think 100,000 children may have newly discovered condition

what they could do now, into what they might be able to do someday.

The families recently learned they share a profound connection. They had each watched their children fail to hit the milestones others did with seeming ease. They were late to crawl and walk. Some have trouble eating and don’t speak. A few have seizures. “Global developmental delays,” the doctors call it when such lags in language, motor skills and cognition happen at the same time.

Doctors couldn’t tell them why their children were experiencing what they were experiencing,

and with no diagnosis, they had no clear prognosis for their kids, or themselves. It was an excruciating mystery that hummed through years of specialist visits and brain scans that yielded no clear answers.

Until last year.

Thanks to a global partnership among genetics researchers and the relentless organizing of parents, the five D.C.-area families who gathered in the park — and many more who aren’t yet aware of the breakthrough — now have a name for their children’s condition. The rare genetic anomaly that causes it was discovered just last year, and families that once felt alone with their questions are now finding answers and one another.

Eleanor clapped when she saw the flower that day. But instead of taking hold of it, she let more than a minute pass, seeming unable to grasp it. Three-year-

old Rae lay beside the two, warming herself in the sun.

Her mom, Leila Levi, marveled at seeing the children together.

“You just hope,” she said, “that the world is kind to them.”

The discovery

A little over a year before, a leading expert on rare diseases at the University of Oxford, Nicky Whiffin, was looking at the data in front of her and thought there was a mistake.

One of her students, Yuyang Chen, had been searching through a vast British database, known as the 100,000 Genomes Project, as part of her team’s effort to ferret out answers for people with undiagnosed conditions. For years, Whiffin’s strategy had been to scour the less-studied regions of the genome. Out of nearly 9,000 patients

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U.S. cuts in Somalia may imperil fight against al-Shabab



ERCIN ERTURK/ANADOLU AGENCY/GETTY IMAGES

Somali soldiers participate in training in 2022 in Mogadishu by the Turkish armed forces’ Somalia Turkish Task Force. Somalia’s government has increasingly turned to Turkey to repel al-Shabab.

Militants are on the march as America’s reduced focus on Africa scrambles global power dynamics

BY KATHARINE HOURELD AND MOHAMED GOBOBE

As President Donald Trump overhauls U.S. policy in Africa — slashing foreign aid programs and paring back assistance for allied forces in the region — al-Shabab militants are on the march in Somalia.

One of al-Qaeda’s best-funded and most lethal global affiliates, al-Shabab has retaken important towns from Somali forces over the past three months. Its fighters previously launched an assault on a U.S. airfield in Kenya and plotted attacks on the U.S. mainland.

Under the second Trump administration, it’s unclear whether Washington believes that the battle against the group should still be a priority — or if the Somali government, long racked

by corruption, is capable of leading the fight.

“The Trump administration is apparently not convinced that al-Shabab represents a direct threat to U.S. interests,” said Matt Bryden, founder of Sahan, a Nairobi-based think tank. But further gains by the group “would have far-reaching implications for U.S. policy in Africa and much of the Middle East,” he said.

During his first term, Trump ordered the U.S. military to leave Somalia and “commute to work” from neighboring countries, a strategy soldiers said was time-consuming and dangerous. Although U.S. troops are back, Washington has withdrawn support for Somali special forces and is reconsidering plans to deploy hundreds of American soldiers

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The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54234

